Still

by Darlene S. Auxajas



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(*Jana begins by singing from the song "Hush Little Baby.")*

She'll be seven months in a couple days. It's crazy how quickly time flies by, because it seems like just yesterday I was trying to convince my husband Richard that having a child was the best thing for us then. I ended up telling him that I once heard on a television show: raising a kid is like raising a dog that slowly learns how to talk. And it worked.

Would you like something to drink? Coffee? Tea? Yes? Okay. (*trip over shoes)*

Oh, these are Richard's shoes. I like to leave them out…just in case. I know it's weird; people keep telling me to just put them away because "he's not coming home, Jana!" But I think it's easier for Annabel if I leave his things out. If not, it's reassuring to me, at least. It's been really hard without him around.

And I know Annabel's barely seven months old but I think she still knows what's going on--maybe not that her father is serving a life time sentence in jail--but she recognizes his presence is gone.

It's not easy being here by myself, but Annabel's my world.

To make matters worse, the newspapers are filled with stories of Richards's trial. "How does his wife feel about this?" "What's the next step for Annabel?" Because in Lenard, Oklahoma--population two hundred--there's nothing else to talk about and everyone knows everyone.

Across the street there's Marcel Stremp: the poster woman for The Old Cat lady—she's got like fifty. Next door to her are the Prices—beautiful family, but Judy Prices' downstairs is like a clown car, you know, just kid after kid after kid. And then next to them are Mr. and Mrs. Jones. They have a son around Annabel's age. They were good friends.

Oh! The kettle! Your tea! Sorry!

We'll make a cup for Richard, too. Just in case he comes home, he'll have a warm cup of tea waiting for him. So he sees his family has missed him.

The press likes to wonder if I'm angry with Richard for what he did. No, I'm not. Because he was a damn good father and husband, no matter what they say. He was loving and hard working and—yes, he had a temper—but he was loyal. I could never be angry. Heartbroken without him, maybe, but no anger. The tabloids all argue that he should be given the

death sentence. But capital punishment is just so controversial these days; they can't make a decision, which is good. Because no one really knows what happened--or understands—and, frankly, Annabel needs a father.

We were a happy family before all this, you know. See our Christmas picture from a last December? We were so happy, (*melt into photo)* posing there. Richard was holding Annabel, but she started to cry and cry so I took her from him. And I'd try explaining that crying was just how she communicates, Richard, but he was just getting angry and yelling and threatening until, "I got it Richard. Maybe she wouldn't cry so much if you didn't yell so often. I'll handle it." (*melt out)*

Annabel's much better now, though. It's still not easy raising a daughter on your own, but she doesn't cry much anymore. She sleeps most of the time. She is so peaceful when she sleeps.

Thank you for visiting. Tragedy is hard and we haven't had many visitors lately. It's like heartbreak is contagious. It's nice having someone else around. Oh, the neighbor Mrs. Jones from down the street came by a few days ago, but that was unexpected. (*melt into scene)*

I was making dinner, and setting the table when the doorbell rang. So I pick Annabel up and go to answer it. It was Mrs. Jones, who needed to borrow some sugar. So I say, "Of course. Just hold Annabel for a moment." And I go back to the kitchen to get her a cup of sugar. And when I return, Mrs. Jones' face had turned a pale blue and she was shaking like a leaf holding my daughter.

"What are you doing? What you're doing to this poor child—to yourself—it's sick, Jana. It's insane. You're crazy, Jana. Crazy". (*melt out)*

Shh, sweetie. Shh. (*Places Annabel in the crib while humming "Hush Little Baby" once more.)*

Maybe I haven't handled Richard's murder trial ideally. I leave the hall lights on at night in case he comes home. I leave his shoes out in the hallway. I set his plate at the table when it's time for supper. But I'm not crazy. I just can't let him go. Not any piece of him—every piece of him needs to stay. We were a family. Now he's in jail for killing…killing…Annabel. Sick of her constant crying, suffocating her perfect little face. (*lean onto crib)* But when I look at her porcelain, still, little body I remember our family. I'm not crazy. Richard and Annabel will live forever.

(*Brush off meltdown, pick up Annabel, and kiss her forehead. Final line to the audience.)* Shh. The baby is sleeping. *(Sings a line of "Hush Little Baby" once more.)*